

kind of board that would give the company a sharper focus and make it ready for the future.

“You will see that Aga’s lack of knowledge of engineering was not a handicap for the real change that was required. Her commitment to her values, of fairness towards all human beings and all stakeholders in the enterprise, especially the least powerful—blue collar workers, small suppliers, small shareholders—was her strength,” says Maira. From his point of view, it enabled the right changes to be made in structure, governance, and management of the enterprise.

Aga says people both inside and outside Thermax wanted her to succeed. And what if things had not worked out? Pat comes the answer. “I loved my company very much, though there were moments of apprehension. I do not have a problem in not knowing something and have always asked for help quite shamelessly.”

M.S. Unnikrishnan, who was in Thermax from 1997 to 2020, and the company’s MD & CEO for 13 years, points out that once Aga is convinced of a certain approach, she will go for it. “Anu operates at a strategic level and always gets the larger picture,” he says. Equally, when people are not performing, the line of thinking is different. “She will never blame the person saying it’s not his mistake but that of the management,” Unnikrishnan says there was no doubt the company would bounce back because of its innate strength and Aga’s ability to deal with the situation.

Aga stands out in so many other ways. For instance, at 61, she decided to step down as Chairperson. “When you encounter success, it goes to your head. Before ego came, I decided to take the decision,” she says.

BEYOND WORK

Social work has had a profound impact on Aga, she feels more motivated doing it. “I know I am in a field where I can contribute,” she says. A meeting with Shaheen Mistri of Akanksha Foundation, which works with underprivileged children, was the starting point. “We got along well. She wanted to follow the Teach For America model.” As Thermax’s promoter, she decided that 50% of dividends must go to philanthropy.

One can’t help but prod her a little on the difference between this and heading Thermax. “Reviving the company was very fulfilling. Social work is more enjoyable,” she says. Understandably, the pressures of running a business are different. “Of course, there was struggle and many sleepless nights. The excitement lay in pushing yourself. Now it’s about having more free time and doing other things.”



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ex-MD & CEO, Thermax

The grounding at Thermax made her a lot tougher. There were multiple challenges to deal with, and now, she has time for the more basic things, like reading. “Today, I can pick and choose the things I want to do,” she says. Aga ensures she is committed to what she does. Time and again, she speaks of the need to not have an ego. “Our stay on this earth is short, our roles are dispensable and our impact inconsequential. So, when you are full of your achievements, it is important to remember these words to bring you back to mother earth,” she says without halting for a second. That clarity of thought is what makes Anu Aga so different. **BT**

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